

be written by employees in the context of their jobs. Open source code will be distributed by large corporations who can afford to give away their software for free, just as they have gained a monopoly. It doesn't matter if competitors can also use their software. Their brand is king and whoever wants to challenge them needs a huge marketing budget to make a difference.

The only way to change this evolution for the better is by establishing a community. Just like Blockchain is challenging the omnipotence of banks, the open source community has to return to its grassroots and reclaim the power of the developer.

Q Where do you see open source and iText in the future?

We are currently working on a future for iText that goes beyond PDF. We recently joined forces with Hancorn, the South-Korean vendor of productivity software. Hancorn is specialised in other document formats (office, epub) and we're working on products that combine iText technology and Hancorn technology.

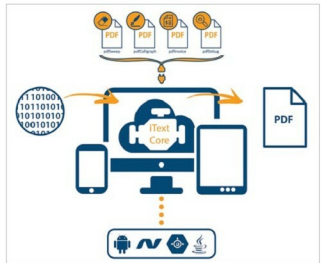
This year, we've rewritten iText from scratch and we have released the new set of PDF libraries as iText 7. It is more modular than any of the previous iText versions and it's also more extensible. We want iText to evolve into a platform on top of which other developers can build their own open source tools and libraries.

Once these tools and libraries gain popularity, we want to help these developers to make money with their project. The AGPL is the ideal licence to achieve this; developers can use iText as a library for free in software they distribute for free, under the same licence. As soon as there's a commercial interest in their software, we will help them with the sales process. We want iText to be a platform developers can use as the foundation for their own development projects, and we want to help them to make money with their project.

We'll introduce developers to our customers so that they can generate revenue. Our customers will have access to more products and more functionality. If we succeed in setting this up, our platform will grow and everybody will win. This is the future I see for open source and for open source developers.

Q How can Indian developers nurture their career through open source?

Knowing that even MIT is abandoning courses such as 'The Structure and Interpretation of Computer Programs' in favour of teaching students how to use software written by others, I fear that we'll see a new form of alphabetism. This is a threat, but also an opportunity; the



The latest version of iText with core and add-ons

world will always need talented software engineers who can build libraries.

Indian developers can nurture their career by avoiding this 'engine-analphabetism'. They shouldn't be content with merely using open source software. They should learn how open source software works. They should look under the hood of the engines they use and understand how these engines work. Open source allows them to do so as the code is open and should become completely transparent to them. This will give them an advantage over all the developers who use open source libraries as if these were black boxes, because they will understand the humming of their engines. This will benefit the quality of their work and make them more

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successful as developers.

The Wall Street Journal recently published an article, 'How the West (and the Rest) got Rich'. The article quotes an American senator, Thomas Massie: "When people ask, 'Will our children be better off than we are?' I reply, 'Yes, but it's not going to be due to the politicians, but the engineers.'"

Being an engineer myself, I believe this to be true, but there's more. The major reason why communities became wealthier was the liberation of ordinary people to pursue their dreams of economic betterment. To quote the article: "Liberated people, it turns out, are ingenious. Slaves, serfs, subordinated women and people frozen in a hierarchy of lords or bureaucrats, are not."

Open source fits perfectly in this philosophy. Open source gives talented developers the freedom to share ingenious ideas with the world and to create wealth in the process—personal wealth as well as wealth for their country and the community, in general. 